SALESFORCE ADMIN COURSE — EPISODE 26

Approval Process in Salesforce

Complete Guide with Practical Demo — Automated Multi-Tier Business Approvals

- What is an Approval Process?
- Entry Criteria & Approval Steps
- Record Locking & Security
- 4 Action Stages (Initial, Approval, Rejection, Recall)
- Build Leave__c Custom Object
- End-to-End Hands-on Demo & Testing

EPISODE	DURATION	LEVEL
26 of Series	~24 Minutes	Intermediate to Advanced

CORE AUTOMATION
Process Governance

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SECTION 1

Introduction & Course Context

⏱ 0:00 – 0:50

Welcome back to the **Salesforce Admin Course!** In the previous episode, we learned how **Queues** prioritize, distribute, and assign shared workloads among teams.

Today, we explore one of the most critical governance and automation pillars in Salesforce: **Approval Processes**.

In corporate environments, sensitive actions cannot simply execute without authorization. Whether an employee requests annual leave, a sales rep offers a 30% contract discount, or an engineer orders expensive hardware, a formal chain of authority must review and approve the request.

SECTION 2

What is an Approval Process & Why Do We Need It?

⏱ 0:50 – 4:00

📌 OFFICIAL DEFINITION

An Approval Process is an automated Salesforce workflow that specifies the sequence of steps required to approve a record. It automates record routing, locks records against unauthorized editing, sends email alerts, and executes field updates upon approval, rejection, or recall.

⚖️ Without Automated Approvals vs. With Salesforce Approval Process

Aspect	❌ Without Approval Process (Manual)	✅ With Approval Process (Automated)
Communication	Messy back-and-forth emails, Slack, or verbal chats	System-generated notifications & in-app approval requests
Data Integrity	Employee can tamper with request dates while under review	**Record is Locked** automatically upon submission
Audit Trail	No central history of who approved what or when	Complete, timestamped **Approval History** related list
Status Tracking	Manual status updating; prone to neglect	Automated field updates (*Pending* ➔ *Approved / Rejected*)

SECTION 3 — CASE STUDY

Real Business Example: Employee Leave Request

⏱ 4:00 – 5:30

🌴 THE SCENARIO: RAHUL'S CASUAL LEAVE APPLICATION

Suppose an employee named **Rahul** wants to take 3 days off from August 15th to August 17th for personal work. He creates a record in the custom object `Leave__c`. Should the leave be approved immediately? **No!** His reporting manager must review company coverage first.

When Rahul clicks **"Submit for Approval"**, Salesforce locks the record, changes the status to *Pending Approval*, and sends an alert to Rahul's manager. If the manager approves, the status flips to *Approved*; if rejected, it flips to *Rejected* and unlocks.

SECTIONS 4 & 5 — ARCHITECTURE

Core Components & The 4 Action Stages

⏱ 5:30 – 15:15

The 4 Action Stages in Every Approval Process:

STAGE 1

Initial Submission

Fires immediately when submitter clicks submit. Locks record, sets status to *Pending*, notifies approver.

STAGE 2

Final Approval

Fires when approver clicks **Approve**. Sets status to *Approved*, unlocks record, notifies submitter.

STAGE 3

Final Rejection

Fires when approver clicks **Reject**. Sets status to *Rejected*, unlocks record, sends feedback email.

STAGE 4

Recall Actions

Fires if submitter recalls request before review. Reverts status to *Draft* and unlocks record for editing.

🔒 WHY RECORD LOCKING MATTERS

If an employee applies for leave from *15 Aug – 17 Aug* and changes the end date to *25 Aug* while the manager is reading the request, major scheduling disasters would occur. **Record Locking** prevents any updates to the record until the manager approves, rejects, or the submitter recalls it!

SECTION 6 — PRACTICAL DEMO PART 1

Creating the Custom Object: Leave__c

⏱ 15:15 – 17:00

To implement our hands-on demo, we define a custom object called `Leave__c` with the following fields:

Field Label	Field Name (API)	Data Type	Values / Parameters
Employee Name	`Employee_Name__c`	Lookup (User)	Identifies the employee requesting time off
Leave Type	`Leave_Type__c`	Picklist	Casual Leave, Sick Leave, Earned Leave, Other
Start Date	`Start_Date__c`	Date	First day of absence
End Date	`End_Date__c`	Date	Last day of absence
Reason	`Reason__c`	Long Text Area	Detailed explanation of the leave request
Status	`Status__c`	Picklist	Draft, Submitted, Pending Approval, Approved, Rejected
Manager	`Manager__c`	Lookup (User)	Identifies the direct reporting manager approver

SECTION 7 — PRACTICAL DEMO PART 2

Configuring the Approval Process in Setup

⏱ 17:00 – 21:00

1. Go to ⚙ **Setup** → Search for `Approval Processes`.
2. Under *Manage Approval Processes For*, select: `Leave`.
3. Click **Create New Approval Process** → Select **Use Standard Setup Wizard**.
4. **Step 1 (Name):** Process Name: `Leave_Request_Approval`.
5. **Step 2 (Entry Criteria):** Select *Criteria are met* → `Leave: Status EQUALS Submitted`.
6. **Step 3 (Approver Field):** Select standard manager hierarchy or custom User lookup (`Manager__c`).
7. **Step 4 (Allowed Submitters):** Choose *Leave Owner / Creator*.
8. **Step 5 (Approval Step):** Add Step 1: *Manager Approval* → Assign to manager.
9. **Step 6 (Initial Submission Actions):** Add Record Lock + Field Update (`Status = 'Pending Approval'`) + Email Alert to Manager.
10. **Step 7 (Final Approval Actions):** Add Field Update (`Status = 'Approved'`) + Record Unlock + Email Alert to Employee.
11. **Step 8 (Final Rejection Actions):** Add Field Update (`Status = 'Rejected'`) + Record Unlock + Notification.
12. **Step 9 (Recall Actions):** Add Field Update (`Status = 'Draft'`) + Record Unlock.
13. **Step 10 (Activation):** Click **Activate**! (Process cannot execute without activation).

SECTION 8 — PRACTICAL DEMO PART 3

Live Testing Scenarios & Approval History

⏱ 21:00 – 23:00

TEST 1: SUCCESSFUL APPROVAL

Happy Path Flow

1. Rahul creates Leave: 15–17 Aug (*Status = Draft*).
2. Sets Status to *Submitted* and clicks **Submit for Approval**.
3. Record locks immediately; Status flips to *Pending Approval*.
4. Manager logs in, opens record, and clicks **Approve**.
5. Status becomes **Approved** and the record unlocks!

TEST 2: REJECTION FLOW

Rejection Path Flow

1. Rahul submits second Leave: 20–30 Aug (peak project deadline).
2. Manager receives request and notices scheduling conflict.
3. Manager enters rejection comments and clicks **Reject**.
4. Status changes to **Rejected**, record unlocks, and Rahul is notified!

📜 APPROVAL HISTORY RELATED LIST

Every action, comment, approval, rejection, and reassignment is permanently documented with user names and timestamps in the **Approval History** related list on the record page, providing full accountability for HR audits.

SECTION 9 — MODERN SALESFORCE ARCHITECTURE

Classic Approval Process vs. Modern Salesforce Flow

⏱ Architecture Perspective

Criterion	📋 Classic Approval Process (Setup)	⚡ Modern Salesforce Flow (Flow Builder)
Setup Complexity	Guided wizard; fast and declarative for standard flows	Visual canvas; requires Flow logic design skills
Branching Logic	Linear steps with standard jump rules	Extremely rich conditional branching and sub-flows
External Integrations	Limited to standard alerts & outbound messages	Can invoke external REST APIs, Slack, or MuleSoft actions
When to Use	Standard manager/director review chains and legacy orgs	Dynamic matrix approvals, Slack-first approvals & custom screens

🎯 Key Takeaways from Episode 26

01

An **Approval Process** automates record review chains, routing records to approvers and locking them against edits.

02

Entry Criteria ensures only eligible records (e.g., `Status = 'Submitted'`) enter the approval pipeline.

03

Record Locking prevents submitters from tampering with values (such as leave dates or discount percentages) while under review.

04

Configured across **4 Action Stages:** *Initial Submission*, *Final Approval*, *Final Rejection*, and *Recall Actions*.

05

Never forget to **Activate** the process after testing in Sandbox before moving to Production.

06

All approval decisions, rejections, and manager comments are permanently logged in the **Approval History** related list.

COMING UP NEXT — EPISODE 27

Next Core Salesforce Admin Feature

Stay tuned as we continue building practical, job-ready Salesforce administration and automation skills!